

Subject: SETI PC meeting, IAC 2021 - chair's notes

Date: Friday, 29 October 2021 at 15:17:47 British Summer Time

From: members@iaaseti.org on behalf of Michael Garrett

To: members@iaaseti.org

Dear All – thanks to everyone that attended the SETI PC meeting this week, I think we had around 50 participants at some point. Lori will generate more detailed notes from the meeting but in the meantime I want to report on some of the main meeting outcomes, basically as I personally summarised them at the end of the meeting. These matters and others raised at the meeting will also be further discussed by and reflected on by the PC exec. As you will see, there is a lot to do. If people feel they can contribute, please let me know.

1. Abstracts of SETI Sessions at the IAC – from now on we will appoint a small SOC to review submitted abstracts – this will include the session chairs and possibly a member of the Exec.
2. Lori Walton (LW) has established good communication with the IAA Office – progress is being made in harmonising the members list held by the PC and the IAA. Members are encouraged to respond to appointment letters they may receive from the IAA, thus accepting membership of the PC. We are discussing how this process can be improved upon. Accepting new members awaits an update to the Charter/ToR.
3. Les Tennen (SETI PC member and member of the IAA Board of Trustees) updated us on the progress being made in updating the Terms of Reference of the various IAA committees, including the SETI PC. Dialogue will continue between Les and the Exec. The expectation is that a new ToR should be adopted at the IAA spring meeting, 2022.
4. The UAP report (majority and minority) presented by Jason Wright (JW) was well received by the PC – a very careful analysis had been made. The current SETI PC ToR exclude any consideration of UFO phenomena. One of the report's recommendations was to conduct a poll of PC members on their position regarding UFO research. The Exec will approach JW and Kathryn Denning (KD) on conducting such a poll.
5. SETI PC meetings are usually conducted under the auspices of the IAC which is organised by the IAF. The IAF Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct was adopted for the meeting:
<https://www.iafastro.org/assets/files/static/legal/iaf-code-of-ethics--professional-conduct.pdf>
6. KD gave a report on Post-detection activities – quite a lot has happened, despite the pandemic. There are some frustrations on the difficulty recently of making progress in this area under the auspices of the PC (IAA). John Elliot presented a UKSRN initiative to establish a Post-detection Hub which aims to draw together experts to work on topics ranging from message decipherment and data analytics to development of regulatory protocols, space law and societal impact strategies. The PC Exec considers this area of research, one of the most important activities of the PC. The PC has a long history of setting and agreeing international policy in the area of post-detection protocols/principles, engaging with the full international community that the IAA itself also represents – it's important this continues as the multi-disciplinary links within the PC are strong, incl. those actively involved in the search itself. Research on this topic can of course be conducted anywhere, and such initiatives are to be welcomed and encouraged.
7. The frequency of PC meetings should be increased to at least twice per year, one of which should be virtual and one that should continue to coincide with the IAC annual meeting.
8. We should consider holding "research only" in addition to the usual business meetings – short events also held online and focused on particular topics e.g. the recent SETI Sessions at the IAC.

Mike Garrett, SETI PC chair.

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